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Grants Pass upsets North Medford at net

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Grants Pass taking steps to avoid future prayer lawsuits

By Vickie Aldous
of the Daily Courier

Grants Pass City Council members are working to develop an open, transparent process to select the people who deliver prayers to start council meetings — part of an effort to keep the city from getting hit with a lawsuit.

This week, the council voted unanimously to keep working on a draft plan.

Through advertising and social media, the city recorder could publicly invite people to apply to deliver an invocation, which could be a prayer, and would schedule the invocations for business meetings of the City Council, according to the draft plan.

The council typically has business meetings twice a month on Wednesday nights.

Grants Pass has gone back and forth on whether to start council meetings with prayer or moments of silence, and in January 2025 resumed prayers delivered by people picked in a behind-the-scenes, informal process.

The prayers often reference God and sometimes Jesus, and frequently ask God to give councilors a sense of unity, and wisdom to make choices that are best for the community.

The city has fielded complaints about the prayers.

City Attorney Stephanie Nuttall said the best way to avoid long, expensive lawsuits is to adopt a process that is constitutional and complies with past court decisions.

"What we want to do is be transparent and open about how we do things, and make sure that transparent, open process is within legal bounds," Nuttall said in a council workshop this week.

Councilor Kathleen Krohn said meetings were starting with prayers for a year-and-a-half before the council heard concerns expressed in public.

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Missing Nevada man found dead, buried near Williams

By Vickie Aldous
of the Daily Courier

Investigators found the buried body of a missing Nevada man on Thursday on property in the Applegate Valley, bringing the death toll to three men in the case, Oregon State Police said today.

Oregon State Police identified the buried remains as those of Andrew Forrest Odom, 67, of Incline Village, Nevada.

He had been reported missing to the Medford Police Department on Oct. 1, OSP said.

On Tuesday of this week, law enforcement had responded to a property in the 10400 block of Williams Highway, just north of Williams, where a suspect fled into a home and shot at OSP detectives, but missed, according to OSP and MPD.

Tactical teams from the Grants Pass Police Department and Josephine County Sheriff's Office responded to the property.

After officers cleared the home, they found Spencer Odom, 40, dead of a self-inflicted gunshot wound. They also discovered Rick Odom, age 70, had been shot and was deceased, OSP said.

Rick Odom was the brother of the missing Nevada man, Andrew Odom, OSP said.

On Thursday, detectives, aided by the Oregon State Police Crime Lab, located human remains buried on the property where the shooting occurred.

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Muralist to brighten up parking garage



Photos by JULIE ANDERSON / Daily Courier

Inspired by Oregon's flora and fauna, Medford artist Anthony Vella stands in front of his murals as he details the work he's putting into them. When complete, the total of four wood panels will be installed at the Bartlett-Middleford parking lot garage connection at 34 N. Bartlett St. in Medford.

Four murals meant to inspire love of nature

By Emma Maple
of the Daily Courier

MEDFORD — As local artist Anthony Vella puts the final touches on his four vibrant murals that are set to bring swaths of color to a parking garage in downtown Medford, he said he hopes people look at the artwork and feel inspired.

"And to just pay attention to the nature," he added. "I would just like for people to just like, listen to the birds talking to you."

Vella's studio for his murals was the back yard of his Medford house, providing the perfect place for him to connect with nature as he was painting. He put birdseed in the yard and would pause to listen to the birds as they chatted with each other. Once, while he was painting, he said that a bird landed on the edge of the mural and just sat there watching him.

The theme guiding Vella's work as he designed the murals was connection. From that word, images encompassing local flora and fauna — like an acorn woodpecker — emerged.

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Medford artist Anthony Vella shows the concept designs for his murals that he presented to the city, which commissioned him to create the panels for the Bartlett-Middleford parking garage.

Pentagon: Firing squad execution to be livestreamed

Hasan set to die Dec. 3, but still has legal options

By Konstantin Toropin, Eric Tucker and Claudia Lauer
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — The firing squad execution of Fort Hood shooter Nidal Malik Hasan will be livestreamed, the Pentagon said Thursday, a stunning revelation about plans for the first military execution in more than 65 years after Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth had described it as being "public."

The Army announced this week that the execution would take place at Fort Hood on Dec. 3 after Hasan was convicted of killing 13 people and injuring 32 others in a shooting at the military base in 2009.

Hegseth, speaking to the conservative TV outlet Real America's Voice on Wednesday, said, "We'll make sure that people are able to watch it, that it's public." Officials in the Pentagon clarified Thursday that the execution would be livestreamed and that more details would follow.

The revelation from Hegseth about the public nature of the execution — let alone one as violent as a firing squad — has raised further questions about how the death penalty is carried out in the U.S., especially after the botched lethal injection of Christa Pike in Tennessee.

Hasan could choose to resist execution and file a habeas petition — a legal request to review the legality of a detention — in civilian court, which could significantly delay the execution, experts said.

"It frankly might outlast the current administration, and who knows if the next one will have the same penchant for executions," said Eugene R. Fidell, a visiting lecturer at Yale Law School specializing in military law.

Deborah Denno, a death penalty expert and law professor at Fordham University, said livestreaming

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